struck us on landing at the airport was the security. There were commandos everywhere and no fans were allowed near the hotel lobby. This was no ordinary match.

Someone had mentioned to us that the surface at Eden Gardens had been relaid with soil brought over from Australia. The first look at the surface seemed to support this statement, with the pitch apparently hard and firm. In fact, it did look like a typical Australian wicket. On that basis, it was unanimously decided that we should field first if we won the toss, particularly because Sri Lanka had chased very well throughout the tournament. Their openers, Sanath Jayasuriya and Romesh Kaluwitharana, had been going for the bowling in the first fifteen overs and had given them fantastic starts in most matches. They had beaten us in the pool stage of the competition and it was important to take early wickets and put them under pressure.

We won the toss and put the Sri Lankans in and got off to a great start, picking up Sanath for one and Kalu for zero. They both got out playing cut shots to third man, vindicating our belief that the wicket was hard and firm. It was only when I came on to bowl that I realized we had misread the wicket. The ball started to hold up and was stopping on the batsmen. The top layer might have been firm enough, but immediately below the surface it was loose. It would clearly not last the full hundred overs and it became even more important to keep Sri Lanka down to a manageable score. Though we managed to restrict Sri Lanka to 251 in their fifty overs, that proved far too many in the end.

When it was our turn to bat the wicket had started doing all sorts of things. The ball was turning and holding up and batting was extremely difficult. Opening, I scored 65 but got out rather strangely to a ball from Sanath Jayasuriya. He was bowling left-arm orthodox spin and the ball hit my pad and rolled off to the on side. I thought there was a quick single and stepped out of the crease. Too late, I saw that the ball had stopped very close to Kaluwitharana, the keeper, and there was no way I could finish the run, but by then it was too late. He dislodged the stumps in a flash and I didn’t bother waiting for the third umpire’s decision because I knew I was out. It was a long and frustrating walk back to the pavilion and I could sense it would not be easy for the batsmen who followed.

Sure enough, we soon lost wickets in a heap, handing Sri Lanka the game. The crowd, desperate for an Indian victory, grew increasingly